



Absent in the Time of the Pandemic

Reading Before Reading

Dr. Adel F. Amer





The Juthur Project



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Language is known by the
intersection of the senses;
meanings, by the multiplicity of
context.





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*To the soul of my mother, that first school,
before whose door I knew no door to
learning;
to Sheikh Habashi, my first teacher, who
taught my hand the letter, and the letter
taught my soul;*

*To Salim, Ali, and Talia;
to every child in the world robbed of the
beauty of their childhood by oppression and
coercion;
to the generations yet to come after we are
gone —*

I offer this work.

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A Disease, a Diagnosis, a Cure

The Book in Three Panels

1 • The Disease	The pandemic of absence. A generation meets the world from behind glass: the hand shrinks to a swiping thumb, the senses to a receiving eye, and the letter arrives with no body to dwell in.
2 • The Diagnosis	A bowed stature. The child is present in the room and absent from the world, withdrawn from his body before he sits down. The harm lies less in the content than in what it displaces.
3 • The Cure	An upright stature. Juthur: reading returned to the body. The letter is touched, heard, walked and breathed before it is seen, so that the road from the hand to the symbol is opened again.

Before You Read

Give the Page to Your Hand

◆ This is a book about the hand, so do not let it reach you through the eye alone. Before the first Gate, I ask of you one minute and three acts:

1. Breathe. One slow breath: the Anfas Ritual in miniature. Presence before performance.

2. Trace. Place a fingertip on the word below and travel it, right to left, the way a child would, slowly enough to feel the turns.



begin here ←

Slowly, right to left; slowly enough to feel the turns.

3. Then read. Whatever your finger kept, the argument that follows is about that.

◆ And one habit for the whole book: at each Gate's threshold, stop for the length of one breath, four or five seconds, before you turn. In the classroom we call this the silence of the bodily question; the book asks it of you too.

◆ If the tracing felt like nothing, note it, and notice, forty pages from now, whether you still think so. The book's claim begins on this page, not in Gate One.

Reader's Guide



The title, the essential question, and the original contributions

Before entering the theoretical architecture of this book, the reader deserves direct answers to three essential questions: What does the title mean? What is the essential question? And what, exactly, is new here?

◆ **First: unpacking the basic concepts**

1. Why “Absent in the Time of the Pandemic”?

The title is not an epidemiological claim, nor a piece of “technopanic” alleging that the screen is a biological virus. It is a deliberate, many-layered metaphor for a withdrawal of many dimensions:

– The essential absence (the sensorimotor body): the child bodily present in the classroom or on the couch, yet with hands still, voice silent, body withdrawn — in sense and in movement — from learning. The screen is not the root of the disease; it is its most visible symptom.

– The cognitive absence (the hijacked mind): the body's presence does not guarantee the mind's. When the tactile-motor input is cut off, attention fragments and the executive functions weaken. The mind is not absent in itself; it is hijacked by the absence of its natural cognitive medium: the moving hand.

– The relational and institutional absence (family, community, systems): families and educators bodily present and mentally absent (“technoference”); institutions absent because they reach for negative prescriptions (“limit the screen”) instead of positive rebuilding (“restore the body”), and import generic multisensory models that overlook Arabic’s morphological particularity and its diglossia.

– The essential message: we are not fighting the screen alone; we are fighting the withdrawal of the body. And the cure is not subtraction but addition: returning the hand, the voice, and the anchored gesture to early learning.

2. What is “Reading Before Reading”?

Traditional schooling begins with the abstract symbol (the letter) and asks the child’s mind to decode it. “Reading Before Reading” reverses this sequence. It is the act of grounding the written symbol in the child’s body (through touch, movement, articulation, and breath) before the eye and the mind are asked to abstract it. It is the preparing of the cognitive soil before the sowing of the symbol. And it rests on a foundational principle: the senses integrate first, and abstraction is then built upon that integration — hand, voice, ear, and eye are partners in forming the single representation; none precedes the others so much as it supports them.

◆ Second: the original contributions (what is new here?)

Although the need for embodied learning is not new (Montessori, Waldorf, and Orton-Gillingham came a century earlier), the theoretical architecture, the specific tools, and the Arabic-specific applications presented in this book are original contributions to the field of early literacy. To protect the intellectual integrity of this work, and to guide the reader, I declare that the following concepts, frameworks, and tools are original contributions of the Juthur Project:

The Eight Original Contributions of the Juthur Project

The Original Contribution	Definition and Function	Why It Is New (the gap it fills)
1. Concrete Reading Theory (CRT)	The theory beneath the method, published in Frontiers in	A falsifiable account of how an arbitrary letter first acquires a

	Education (Amer, 2026). It proposes that durable early literacy depends on functional anchors: multisensory, emotionally charged structures hypothesized to bind the written symbol to the child's sensorimotor experience.	bodily ground, with stated neural predictions and declared conditions of refutation. This book carries it one step further, from the letter to the Arabic root, and marks that step as its own hypothesis.
2. The Golden Pentad (al-Mukhammas)	The teacher's five sequenced acts: Endear, Sort, Inspire, Delight, Enable.	It translates an abstract philosophy of the soul into a practical pedagogical sequence for the teacher, replacing instruction that

		begins with the symbol.
3. The Learner's Heart	The child's four inner states generated by the Pentad: "I know" → "I want" → "I can" → "I create."	It maps the child's inner journey through Islamic philosophy of the soul, distinguishing precisely between volition (the will) and capacity (motor-cognitive readiness).
4. The Grounded Essential Ladder (Essential Ladder)	The soul's six degrees: Sensation → Perception → Affective Engagement → Volition → Capacity → Act.	It offers a graded, continuous psychological ladder missing from Western embodied-cognition frameworks, restoring the classical

		distinction between striving and capacity.
5. The Mirsah (sensory anchor)	A deliberate sensorimotor experience paired with a linguistic unit to fix it in the body; in this book's own mapping (not the paper's), a classroom experience designed to help form what CRT calls a functional anchor.	To my knowledge, the first pedagogical tool designed specifically to bridge the cognitive distance of Arabic diglossia (from the lived colloquial to written Standard Arabic, fuṣḥā) through bodily enactment.
6. The Lathatha Index	An observational measure of the child's felt bodily engagement (from 0 to 3).	It moves the measure of learning success from "cognitive output" to "felt bodily presence

		and delight,” as evidence of embodied readiness prior to standardized testing.
7. The Motor-Imprint Hypothesis	The falsifiable claim that embodying the root generates a motor imprint that eases the decoding of its derivatives.	It moves multisensory learning from “it works” to a specific, testable, falsifiable neuro-pedagogical mechanism, isolating embodiment from general effects of attention or motivation.
8. The NaRF Cycle and Jumbaz al-Huruf	The ten-station lesson rhythm (Nafas–Rasm–Fahm: breath–	It provides a minute-by-minute classroom rhythm that

tracing—
understanding)
and whole-body
letter gymnastics.

enacts the “body
first” principle
and prevents
relapse into a
flood of abstract
symbols.

Notation Guide

A mark on every claim, in the service of integrity

In this book I apply an explicit system of notation to every claim, in the service of integrity:

- An element grounded in the heritage or in settled science. What the tradition transmits, or what the laboratory has established — it holds, as of now.

◆ The author's own reasoning or pedagogical synthesis. A joining, an interpretation, or a bridge the author builds — defensible, but his.

▲ A hypothesis or falsifiable claim — awaiting measurement, or the subject of live scientific debate. Named as such, with its own conditions of refutation.



Preface: What Is Juthur?



A method and its pillars

Juthur is a teaching method for Arabic reading in early childhood (roughly ages 4–8), built on grounding the written symbol in the child's body before abstracting it. It is not a general theory of education, nor a program of

psychological care; it is a way of teaching, with defined pillars and a classroom apparatus that can be implemented and measured.

◆ Three conceptual pillars make it distinct (a narrow intersection found together in no other method, to the best of my knowledge):

1. Grounding the Arabic root: Arabic is a derivational, root-based language, so the root and its relation to the pattern are embodied in movement — not the single letter alone.

2. The Essential Ladder: a psychological sequence grounded in Islamic philosophy of the soul (Consciousness, then the six degrees: Sensation → Perception → Affective Engagement → Volition → Capacity → Act) that orders the learner's journey step by step.

3. Bridging diglossia: turning the distance between the colloquial and Standard Arabic into a bodily crossing (the *Mirsah*), not an obstacle to be ignored.

◆ A classroom apparatus brings the pillars down to earth: the Golden Pentad (the teacher's acts) → the Learner's Heart (the child's states), then the Sensory Matrix, the stations of the letter's journey, the Living Root, and the Thirty-Day Map.

▲ An empirical, falsifiable pillar: the Motor-Imprint Hypothesis — that embodying the root generates a motor imprint that eases the decoding of derivatives. It is the heart of this book's own claim, the step from letter to root that goes beyond the published theory, and the part most exposed to field testing; and it comes with a proposed experimental design (the chapter "The Motor-Imprint Hypothesis").

◆ And what is this book to the method? It is its manifesto: it explains why Juthur was born now (the diagnosis of “absence”), what its mission is (returning the body to the learning of reading), and how it holds up intellectually. The technical detail, the method laid out in full, and the measurement belong to the academic volume (Juthur Reads) and the peer-reviewed papers. This book presents the method and defends it; it does not claim to have proven it — proof is the laboratory’s work.

◆ And a word about the title before we begin: “Absent in the Time of the Pandemic” does not claim that the screen is a “pandemic” ravaging the child’s development — the direct statistical effect of screen time on language development is small (the chapter “The Absence” acknowledges this openly; the pooled effect on executive functions is not even statistically significant: Bustamante et al., 2023; $r \approx 0.05$). “The pandemic” here is a deliberate metaphor for something deeper: the absence of the body from the learning of reading. The screen is not the first

cause but an accelerant of this absence — its most visible symptom, not the root of its disease. Whoever asks of this book an epidemiology of screens has mistaken its door; whoever reads it in search of the absent body has found the right one.



In the Voice of the One Not Yet Come

I am the one who has not yet come... and yet, from this moment, I am in your hands.

Do not look for me in pictures; I am too small for you to see, and too large for any measure to contain. I am a bundle of light folded into a seed, and I am the hand that has not yet closed around anything, and I am the ear that listens to you from behind a wall of water.

They say I know nothing yet, and that is not true. I know the warmth of your voice before I understand your words, and I know the rhythm of your heart before I know my own name. My body knows. This is the first knowledge that came down with me into the world: that the world is touched before it is read.

But I fear one thing. I fear arriving into a time when people hold a cold light in their hands and forget that I have hands of my own. I fear being born present in the room and absent from the world; my eyes open upon glass that gleams, my heart closed to my mother's face.

This book is not for me; I do not read yet. This book is for you: you who will carry me, you who will plant me, you who will teach me how to become a tree. Read it before I come. Read it... a reading before reading.

I do not want much. I do not want toys that light up and make sounds, nor a room filled with things that glitter. I want a hand to hold me when I cry, a voice to tell me stories even if I do not understand, and a face that looks at me when I look at it. These are small things, but they are the soil without which I do not sprout.

And if a screen keeps you from me for an hour, that is an hour of my life that will not return. I do not grow up twice. And every look you give me now becomes, years

later, a root that holds me when the wind blows. So look at me while I am still a seed; the first look can never be made up.